contrast to its reluctance to intervene, even indirectly, in the 1971 Bangladesh conflict despite being exhorted to do so by the Nixon Administration. What changed during this period was a determination to break up the cooperative strand in the ties between the US and USSR that was constricting China's strategic space. So it utilized both the Vietnam and Afghanistan conflicts to that end. And thus created a favourable political climate for the flow of Western investments. So much so, that even when the Tiananmen incident happened, there were enough advocates abroad to mitigate the damage. Having more than achieved its strategic objectives when the USSR broke up, China altered course and made up with a Russia coming under pressure. For an Indian assessing this period, it is telling that a competitor willing to take greater risks and pursue strategic clarity not only got a decade's head start in economic growth but also a more favourable geopolitical balance. So much again for consistency.

Although the 1960s were termed the dangerous decade because of political uncertainty and national fragility, the term could as well be applied to the 1990s. The 1991 balance of payments crisis only brought to head what was an accumulation of policy outcomes of the previous generation. A quarter century later, the literature on the happenings largely focus on the domestic challenges. The foreign policy situation, however, was no less traumatic, and it took considerable ingenuity and courage to chart a path of recovery. The dissolution of the USSR had undercut a fundamental premise on which Indian foreign policy operated since 1971, perhaps even since 1955. Even worse, the Russia that followed immediately was focused almost exclusively on the West and briefly downgraded its ties with India. In such a situation, the Indian response was very mature. Maintaining the importance of Russia, it engaged the US much more intensively while also reaching out to China. That the Indian economy also opened out during this period was clearly helpful for these relationships.

In this period of flux, the ASEAN played a very critical role in facilitating India's interactions with Asian economies and serving as a new focal point for a foreign policy whose moorings had become shaky. The importance of the growing partnership with ASEAN and India's membership of the ASEAN Regional Forum had long-term implications that could not have been foreseen then. It not only changed Indian thinking but also opened a